6

Kings, Queens and X Factors

It was a delightful Delhi winter afternoon in early January 2014, a light sun offering just the right dose of warmth. Senior BJP leader Arun Jaitley was holding his annual lunch at his 9, Ashoka Road residence, just next to the party office. The party's top leadership had gathered at the high table—food seemed to unite Advani, Jaitley, Sushma and Rajnath as they prepared for the start of the big election year. The spread was classic north Indian and there were even cooks flown in from Amritsar by a private caterer for the occasion. From *kulcha chole* to *bheja* masala to butter chicken, this was a lunch designed to break the cholesterol barrier.

The mood was upbeat with the party having done well in the December assembly elections in four states. Some BJP leaders were already being asked what portfolios they wanted in the next government at the Centre. I said to the BJP chief spokesperson Ravi Shankar Prasad that he could well be the next information and broadcasting minister once again. 'Why, you don't want me to get a promotion!' he laughed. I suggested he have another *kesar kulfi* for good luck.

The star attraction, though, was seated at one of the side tables. Amit Shah was back from Lucknow and was surrounded by journalists hanging on to his every word. Only, the talk wasn't so much about his UP adventure as it was about the newest sensation on the political stage. Arvind Kejriwal's AAP party had made a Sourav Ganguly-like debut by forming a government in Delhi just a few weeks earlier.

The AAP leader was splashed all over the media. He was CNNIBN's Politician of the Year; the *Times of India* and *India Today* had chosen him as their Newsmaker of the Year. 'You media people have got carried away by